structure a system based on kinship (bhai-beta) and clan (gotra) was developed. Because these repeated, ferocious battles to the death could sometimes mean the end of several generations of clansmen, polygamous marriages were introduced to supply a sufficient quantity of men. The Rajputs unabashedly compared themselves with the native plant richke (lucerne), a fodder plant for horses, which grows more vigorously the more it is grazed. Dying extravagantly in battle became something of a Rajput specialty, extolled by bards and encouraged by wives and mothers. So resolute was the bravery of these Rajput warriors that neither had the Delhi Sultanate, nor any of the other rulers of north India, the Khaljis, the Lodis, or the Surs, been able to subdue these Rajasthani tribes or incorporate their lands into their empires.

The Kachhwahas of Amer were a small, resolutely insignificant family plagued by the pedestrian Rajput problem of polygamous households leading to succession disputes. They were also vulnerable to repeated acts of territorial expansion by their more powerful Rathore neighbours. Raja Bharmal was contesting the seat of Amer with Puran Mal, one of his many brothers, who had usurped the support of the Mughal governor, Mirza Sharafuddin Hussain. Bharmal, at over fifty years of age, was a patient strategist and a careful judge of men. He now sought Akbar’s help in dislodging Puran Mal and in exchange offered him a daughter in marriage, thereby altering the fate of the province of Amer forever.

The Rajput clans had used marriages as signs of submission to victorious chiefs for a long time. Apart from Hindu and Rajput rulers, defeated chieftains had already married daughters to Muslim rulers such as the Ghoris and the Tughlaqs of Delhi. In more recent times, Rao Maldeo of Marwar had married a daughter to Sultan Mahmud of Gujarat and another daughter to Islam Shah Sur. But the Mughal–Rajput alliance that would arise out of this first, unassuming relationship between Akbar and the Kachhwahas, making the Rajputs stakeholders in the fortunes of the Mughal Empire, would lead to conquests and glory that neither side could have anticipated at the time. Akbar agreed to Raja Bharmal’s proposal and in return induced Mirza Sharafuddin Hussain to hand over the raja’s relatives he had kept hostage. Akbar then carried on to Ajmer while the raja went to Sambhar to arrange for his daughter’s wedding, complete with all the elaborate Hindu rites. In Ajmer, Akbar met up with the ladies of the harem, who had been brought there by Maham Anaga, and the Mughal